



MONTHLY UPDATE

Botswana: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-18 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Payments and cross-border links carried the month. Three payment products entered service — [a cashless payment and financing partnership for taxi operators](#), [a wallet-linked card](#), and [e-commerce acceptance for a foreign card scheme extended across nine African markets](#) — all three private, and none of them a public rail.

Regional agreements were the other half: [an ICT memorandum with Namibia signed at Kasane on 7 August](#), alongside the completed cross-border fibre interconnection it sits over, [an innovation memorandum with South Africa](#), and [a regional tourism univisa agreement approved at the SADC summit on 17 August](#). Domestically the statistics office [launched its second statistics development strategy for 2026-2030](#), and the health ministry [signed a ten-year health-systems partnership with a foreign operator](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The data policy is being turned into something implementable. A five-day [data governance capacity-building and stakeholder engagement was held from 7 to 11 September to translate the national data policy's principles and direction into a national data strategy](#), with continental and European support. No draft strategy or adoption date is published.

Data protection

The commencement instrument behind the data-protection regime is now held in full: [Statutory Instrument 86 of 2021 brought the Data Protection Act No. 32 of 2018 into operation on publication on 15 October 2021](#). It dates a regime the repository had been carrying from its 2024 re-enactment, and it is the kind of document that settles when an obligation actually started rather than when it was last restated.

Regional collaboration

The [ICT memorandum with Namibia was signed at Kasane on 7 August](#) between the two ICT ministries, with their operators and regulators present, covering digital transformation, cybersecurity, connectivity and skills development. It had been [announced for signature the day before](#) as an extension of existing roaming and submarine-cable transit cooperation. The signed instrument itself is not held, and no term, funding or data-governance provision is published; what the two sides did publish alongside it is operational, and is recorded under connectivity below.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The [Plumtree-Bulawayo section of a regional fibre corridor](#) went live on 6 July, carrying traffic at 800Gbps equipped on equipment rated over 10Tbps, with a second phase to Livingstone due September 2026. The corridor is stated as a Botswana-Zimbabwe-Zambia route; the live section is inside Zimbabwe and no Botswana segment is dated.

The western corridor did produce a Botswana segment. Alongside the Kasane memorandum the two sides disclosed that [MTC has completed the Gobabis-Buitepos fibre link, now interconnecting with BoFiNet at Charles Hill](#) – described as the first direct cross-border fibre link between the two operators – and costed the Trans-Kalahari Corridor's remaining 4G gaps at about N\$52 million across 13 new sites. The two national incident-response teams are also said to be deepening cooperation. No capacity, commissioning date or traffic figure is published for the fibre link.

Domestic access moved on a much smaller scale. The backbone company [completed its 2025/26 local access projects at P43m, taking fibre to Moshupa, Ramotswa/Taung and Thamaga and connecting 191 customers – 68, 66 and 57 across the three – with 210 construction jobs](#). The customer count is the operator's own and is a count of connections, not of premises passed.

The mobile side put a figure and a date on the next generation. The incumbent operator [committed more than P240 million for 2026/27, targeting commercial 5G in strategic areas of the capital for October 2026 before an accelerated rollout to other cities and key villages, with 599 mobile-site capacity upgrades in the programme](#). It is a commitment and a target, with no coverage obligation or spectrum award attached. The starting point is a fourth-generation network the same private census calls near-universal and names among the country's competitive advantages, alongside extensive fibre and growing data-centre capacity ([census](#)); the coverage figure itself is a private compilation's, not a regulator return, and the progress report carries it.

Data Storage

The Kala data centre [completed its first full quarter of continuous operation to 30 June, with revenue the company itself describes as modest and at proof-of-concept scale](#). It is designed for up to 1 MW and expansion is subject to funding. The repository holds nothing on the facility before September 2025.

Energy

The facility's power is the unusual part. [On-site gas-fired generation is supplemented by solar introduced to cover periods of lower gas availability, with battery and compressed-gas storage under review](#) – solar specified as firming for gas, the reverse of the usual diesel-backup arrangement. [An initial 5 MW solar development was assessed during the quarter and an extension of the gas gathering network to connect a further production well is stated subject to funding](#); neither carries a capital cost, approval or date, and the company states both are work-programme items rather than guidance. The second gates the data centre: capacity growth turns on upstream gas work rather than on demand.

The price of the energy the sector runs on is under review, and the utility's own case is a large one: its consultation paper [makes the case for a 46% tariff rise on a P9.585bn revenue requirement against a P3.477bn funding gap](#). It is an application rather than a determination: no regulator decision, effective date or data-centre tariff schedule accompanies it, and the repository still holds no measured electricity cost for any digital facility in the country.

Cybersecurity

A published account documents a [growing digital safety problem](#). It is journalistic and carries no measure: no incident count, reporting route or response instrument accompanies it, which is what the record can and cannot say.

DPI

Data Exchange

The identity register is being opened to banks: the bankers' association [launched a national eKYC project letting banks verify customers against the national citizen database](#), with no go-live date or data-protection arrangement stated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The credential's problem this month is forgery rather than production. The labour and home affairs ministry [is contending with a cartel producing fake identity documents](#). That is a statement about the integrity of the Omang credential, not only about the backlog in issuing it, and the two compound each other: a slow replacement queue is what makes a forged card useful. No arrest, prosecution or volume figure is in the record held.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The month's three payments developments are all commercial and narrow. A commercial bank and the Yellow Light Taxi Association [launched card acceptance on the bank's mobile tap product for taxi operators in Gaborone on 9 August](#), with access to business loans of up to P60,000 conditioned on the formal banking history the operators build through it. It is one bank and one association; no operator count, uptake figure or fee schedule is stated, and the credit on offer is tied to banking with the institution providing the terminal. Nine days later a remittance operator [issued a card on its wallet through a commercial bank and an international scheme](#), adding ATM withdrawal, in-store payment and domestic online purchase to a wallet that carried transfer and cash-out only. The operator's own account of the Companion Card puts the point of it plainly: [no separate bank account is required and the card works across every mobile network in the country, against an estimated 38 per cent of adults unbanked](#). Here too there is no customer count, issuance volume or fee schedule on the record. A commercial bank and an international card scheme then [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Botswana on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Botswana. The national payment switch and the citizen wallet both remain at Planned.

A fourth came with a bank's annual results: FNBB [said its eWallet will send funds directly into all three mobile-money platforms](#), with no start date or fee published.

Registries

The vital-statistics report [describes the births and deaths registration system as partially automated and decentralised](#) — a description of the system rather than a change to it. Separately, government [committed in Parliament on 19 August to an electoral-reform package including electronic voter registration](#), with no bill, supplier, cost or date attached.

Sectoral management information systems

The health ministry [signed a ten-year strategic partnership with the operator of Abu Dhabi's health information exchange on 22 August](#), covering pharmaceutical and medical supply and opening cooperation on digital health transformation, genomics, precision medicine and capacity development. The fuller account is [the counterparty's](#)

[own](#), which adds a national genomics programme. No contract value, list of systems, data-handling term or governance arrangement is published, so a ten-year commitment over health data sits on the ledger with nothing describing what it obliges either side to do.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A tax adviser's reading of the new Value Added Tax Act, in force since 1 July, [puts mandatory electronic invoicing among the obligations the Act provides for](#), which would give the revenue service transaction-level visibility as sales occur. No start date, threshold or scope has been published, and the reading is the adviser's rather than the revenue service's.

Technology

ICT Industry

The state wholesale network operator [presented its first integrated report, for the year ended 31 March 2025, at its annual general meeting on 13 August, with revenue down on the year, and reported its 2025/26 local access projects complete](#). Publishing an integrated report is itself part of the movement: the operator has not accounted for itself in one document before.

Innovation ecosystem

The sector was counted for the first time. An inaugural census puts more than 100 startups in operation across fintech, e-commerce, agritech, artificial intelligence, mobility, edtech and healthtech, and states the whole of what they have raised since 2019 as a single figure the progress report carries ([census](#)) - where the 2021 diagnostic could only call the early-stage finance market nascent. The count is the publisher's own compilation rather than a deal database, and the report carries no recoverable address, so it is cited to its catalogue entry.

Inclusion

Access to services

The Ministry of Youth and Gender Affairs [describes the Department of Gender Affairs as secretariat to the National Gender Commission](#), the standing institution behind this subject. Nothing else in the inclusion ledger moved in this window; the gender-based violence programme and the one-stop centres both date from earlier in the year.

Digital divides

The creative sector was surveyed for a digital purpose. A two-day multistakeholder workshop in Gaborone [mapped Botswana's creative industries to shape a more inclusive digital future](#). A mapping is a starting position; the record held carries no output from it and no policy it is to feed.

Data

National statistics

The statistics office and the national university [launched a second Statistics Development Strategy for 2026 to 2030 on 12 August](#), framed as a roadmap to an agile and responsive statistical system and aligned to the twelfth national development plan. No budget, delivery milestone or indicator set is published with it.

One absence in that system was dated this month. No gambling participation statistics are held as the country moves to lower the legal betting age, while an investigation reports [unregistered betting influencers drawing 4,000 to 15,000 responses to a single betting slip and directing followers to bookmakers through referral links](#). The activity is documented and the population is not counted, which is the gap a statistical strategy would have to close.

Geopolitics

China activities

China's ambassador [publicly offered AI cooperation in smart mining, digital government and talent training, pitching Chinese AI technology as a lever for economic diversification and pointing to a July 2026 pledge of 5,000 AI training places for developing countries and AI application cooperation centres for bodies including the African Union](#). It is an offer rather than an instrument: no Botswanan response, memorandum or programme is on file.

Gulf/UAE activities

The heads of agreement behind the data centre are unchanged, and the [operator's quarterly account of 3 August does not name the counterparty](#). It remains the only source of its kind the repository holds for Botswana at any date.

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